

» COVER STORY

NO MORE NEARLY MEN

RAJAT PATIDAR LEADS, VIRAT KOHLI INSPIRES — A DEFINING IPL SEASON FOR RCB ENDS IN REDEMPTION AFTER YEARS OF NEAR-MISSES AND FAN ANGUISH.

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After years of toil, there were tears of joy.

Seventeen years. 6,255 days. 286 games.

At long last, Royal Challengers Bengaluru broke its title jinx and lifted the Indian Premier League (IPL) trophy, sending players, fans and an entire city into rapturous celebration.

The women's team had already won the Women's Premier League title. A year later, it was the men's turn to finally add silverware to a cabinet that had remained empty since the tournament's inception in 2008.

Fittingly, it was also a tribute to the franchise's longest-serving cricketer and former captain, Virat Kohli — who, in his own words, gave his "youth, prime and experience" to

RCB and helped shape it into what it is today.

Despite boasting some of the finest cricketers over the years, RCB consistently stumbled at crucial moments. Seasons came and went, heartbreaks mounted, and the fan base waited through near-eternity before their war cry — *Ee sala cup namde* — was finally realised.

Led by a calm and composed Rajat Patidar, this version of RCB had